

AI-Designed Portrait Guide #007

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-14 hours Subject Portrait / Figure Study Pencils Prismacolor Premier

Every guide in this series is generated by Claude — an AI trained on professional art instruction, anatomy theory, color science, and fine arts critique frameworks. It analyzes the reference, identifies the technical challenges, and writes a sequenced plan before I touch a pencil.

Then I follow it exactly and document what happens — so the results are verifiable, not theoretical.

At the end of each guide, there's a prompt you can run on your own work to get the same level of critique.

PENCIL & PROMPT

• COLOR PALETTE



Beige
PC997

Foundational warm undertone wash establishing color temperature across entire face



Light Peach
PC927

Primary light skin tone for illuminated facial planes and highlight areas



Peach
PC939

Warm midtone bridging light and shadow, establishing facial form and structure



Salmon Pink
PC1001

Chromatic warm shadow introducing natural shadow temperature and luminous depth



Beige Sienna
PC1080

Warm mid-shadow deepening form while maintaining warm undertone and avoiding ashy greys



Ginger Root
PC1084

Warm undertone layer for continued luminosity and temperature consistency in transitions



Peach Beige
PC1085

Transitional glaze creating color coherence and smooth value transitions between zones



Cream
PC914

Warm highlight tone and brightest light area (reserved for strategic highlight placement)



10% Warm Grey
PC1050

Foundational cool undertone for shadows creating optical mixing base



20% Warm Grey

PC1051

Mid-value cool transitional layer and atmospheric color in shadow structure



30% Warm Grey

PC1052

Shadow value establishment and structural cool undertone for chromatic depth



Black Cherry

PC1078

Chromatic dark shadow with magenta undertone (never neutral—prevents muddy appearance)



Henna

PC1031

Warm brown shadow accent preventing cool-only shadows, adds earthy warmth to dark areas



Burnt Ochre

PC943

Warm dark shadow for deepest values maintaining portrait warmth and natural appearance



Copenhagen Blue

PC906

Cool eye color base creating color contrast against warm face and visual focal point



Black

PC935

Darkest value definition for pupils, eyelashes, and deepest feature shadows



Blush Pink

PC928

Natural lip undertone establishing warm pink base for mouth area



White

PC938

Final burnishing highlight creating luminous surface quality and sealant layer

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

<i>What is the subject?</i>	Young male portrait with serene neutral expression, three-quarter head turn showing approximately 45-degree angle. Naturally youthful facial structure, fair-to-light skin tone, and delicate features.
<i>Material characteristics</i>	Smooth human skin with minimal texture, subtle natural porosity suggesting healthy complexion. Hair appears fine, silky with natural blonde or honey-toned coloring showing natural light-responsiveness. Eyes demonstrate natural moisture, visible iris color with depth, and luminous sclera reflecting ambient light.
<i>Geometric structure</i>	Classic adult male facial proportions with rounded cheekbones, soft jawline, and refined nose structure. Head position creates slight downward tilt with three-quarter view allowing both ear visibility and full facial plane observation. Facial planes clearly defined through tonal shifts rather than contour lines, demonstrating form through value modulation.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

<i>Light source direction</i>	Soft directional illumination from upper left (approximately 45-degree angle), diffused quality suggesting large light source (studio softbox or overcast window light). No harsh shadows present; light creates gentle modeling across planes.
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HIGHLIGHT

Upper left cheekbone receives brightest illumination with minimal shadow intrusion. Left forehead, left side of nose bridge, upper eyelid on camera-left eye, and left jaw plane receive secondary bright light. Highlight areas show subtle warm pink undertone visible within light.

LIGHT AREA

Mid-face receives consistent even illumination. Right cheekbone transitions gradually from light to midtone rather than sharp boundary. Upper face across forehead maintains light value. Transition areas show gradual shift rather than distinct lines.

MIDTONE

Right side of face contains primary midtone values, particularly cheekbone area. Nose receives warm midtone across bridge with specific shadow placement beneath. Upper eyelids show subtle midtone modeling suggesting eye socket depth. Transition zones between light and shadow occupy most facial area.

SHADOW

Eye sockets contain subtle warm shadow without harsh darkness. Underside of nose shows soft shadow maintaining warm cast. Right side of jaw shows gentle shadow transition. Shadow beneath lower lip and beneath chin demonstrates soft form indication. Neck shows continued shadow direction indicating unified light.

CAST SHADOW

Minimal cast shadow visible; subtle shadow beneath chin where neck meets face suggests form. Shadow on right neck/shoulder demonstrates continued light direction. No sharp cast shadow lines; all transitions soft and diffused.

Edge quality notes

Edges predominantly soft throughout with minimal hardness. Slight edge sharpening on camera-left cheekbone where light peaks. Hair edges feather softly into background with no visible outline. Facial contours use edge softness to convey three-dimensionality rather than line drawing. Mouth area shows softest edges despite color saturation.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

Decidedly warm throughout with consistent golden-peachy undertone. Color temperature remains warm from light through midtone areas, with cool accents strictly reserved for shadow structure and eye color only. Warm dominates portrait creating cohesive luminous feeling.

Light zone tendency

Light areas trend warm and moderately saturated with peachy-pink undertones. Highlights contain cream, pale warm yellow, and warm pink. No cool blues or greens appear in light areas except intentional eye reflection. Warm pink visible in upper cheekbone light area.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadows shift toward cool with subtle blue-grey undertones, but maintain warm component through brown and sienna additions. Never purely cool; shadows contain essential warm element for natural appearance. Shadow appears warm-cast by comparison to cool undertone foundation.

Special color areas

Eyes contain cool Copenhagen blue base with warm brown-gold iris rim creating color temperature contrast. Lips show natural rosy-pink with decidedly warm undertone preventing blue-cast appearance. Hair contains warm blonde tones with darker warm brown shadows showing light-responsiveness. Cheekbone shows highest saturation and warmest pink.

Saturation distribution

Highest saturation concentrated in midtone values: cheekbones (most saturated area), lips, and nose planes. Moderate-to-lower saturation in light areas creating subtle warmth rather than obvious color. Lowest saturation in deep shadows and extreme highlights maintaining believability. Saturation increases gradually toward focal point areas.

OI Value Foundation & Undertone Mapping

Entire face including forehead, cheeks, nose, chin, neck—all visible skin areas

Barely-there pressure with directional horizontal strokes following facial contours, maintaining visible paper texture throughout

Light pressure

Begin with extremely light pressure, creating an invisible transparent wash of PC997 Beige across entire face to establish warm undertone foundation. Use horizontal directional strokes following facial anatomy, allowing paper texture to show through—this layer should be barely visible when complete. This foundational color temperature layer locks in warmth and prevents the common error of cool cast developing as darker values are added. Do not attempt any modeling, shadow placement, or detail; purely establish undertone temperature as foundation for all subsequent layers.

COLORS  PC997 Beige

◆ *This step appears insignificant but is absolutely critical—many failed portraits lose warmth because this invisible foundation is skipped. The base must be so subtle you question whether color was applied. This allows all subsequent warm tones to maintain luminosity without appearing orange or muddy.*

02 Initial Value Mapping with Cool Foundation

Shadow areas exclusively: eyesockets, underside of nose, right side of face, neck shadow, beneath chin

Light application respecting shadow boundaries, following facial form, minimal strokes maintaining paper visibility

Light pressure

Using very light pressure with PC1050 (10% Warm Grey), apply only in designated shadow areas to establish cool undertone structural foundation. Avoid light areas entirely; this layer is strictly structural underpinning for shadows. The cool foundation underneath will optically mix with warm colors layered above, creating naturalistic shadow temperature through color mixture rather than muddy overmixing. This counter-intuitive approach—cool underneath, warm on top—creates dimensional shadows that glow rather than recede flatly.

COLORS

■ PC1050 10% Warm Grey

♦ *Transparency is essential—the cool grey must remain barely visible at this stage. This 'shadow primer' creates the optical mixing opportunity that sophisticated portrait artists exploit. Rushing this step or applying too much pressure ruins the transparent layering effect.*

03 Establish Light Plane Base

All illuminated areas: forehead, left cheekbone, left side of nose, upper left face planes, left temple, left jaw

Directional strokes following facial planes, variable pressure creating subtle modeling within light areas, heavier pressure on cheekbone highlight zone

Light to Medium pressure

Apply PC927 Light Peach with light-to-medium pressure to all areas receiving primary light. Follow light direction carefully—left cheekbone receives most saturated application because direct light hits there. Areas receiving diffused light receive lighter, more transparent application. Use directional strokes following facial anatomy from center of face outward, establishing clear value separation between light and shadow zones. This layer establishes the primary warm skin tone and begins three-dimensional form suggestion.

COLORS

■ PC927 Light Peach

♦ *Avoid uniform saturation of the same color—sophisticated rendering uses pressure variation to suggest subtle modeling within light areas. The cheekbone where light peaks should be noticeably more saturated than the temple area receiving softer, diffused light. This variation creates natural luminosity.*

04 Midtone Establishment & Form Building

Rightside of face, mid-cheekbone transitional area, nose structure, areas between light and shadow

Blending directional strokes, slightly heavier pressure than light layer, following facial structure and creating soft transitions

Medium pressure

Layer PC939 Peach over midtone areas with medium pressure to establish middle values and warm tone throughout the face. This color bridges the gap between light peach in illuminated areas and deeper shadows to come. Apply with slightly heavier pressure than light layer but remaining transparent enough to see underlying warm foundation. Build form gradually—peach tone should transition smoothly from light peach without visible demarcation. Begin suggesting subtle nose structure and jawline definition with slightly heavier strokes.

COLORS  PC939 Peach

♦ *This layer makes or breaks three-dimensional appearance. Rather than layering more of the same color repeatedly, use this warmer peach tone to suggest warm ambient light bouncing in midtone values. This creates luminosity through color temperature modulation rather than just value addition.*

05 Shadow Layer One: Warm Shadow Introduction

Right side of face, eyesockets, underside of nose, chin shadow, neck shadow—all shadow areas from light plane

Medium pressure respecting shadow direction, following facial structure, maintaining transparency to show layering, leaving micro-highlight areas untouched

Medium pressure

Apply PC1001 Salmon Pink to shadow areas with medium pressure, sitting atop the previously applied 10% Warm Grey foundation. This warm pink-salmon tone establishes the essential warm component of shadows, creating the optical mix (cool grey + warm salmon = natural shadow temperature). Do not darken significantly at this stage—still building luminosity while establishing form. The salmon pink should remain transparent enough to see underlying color layers. This is where the portrait begins demonstrating why chromatic warm shadows are superior to neutral greys for skin rendering.

COLORS  PC1001 Salmon Pink

♦ *Prismacolor's transparency is the secret weapon here. You should distinctly see the cool grey undertone through the warm salmon pink, creating visual depth and complexity before any darker values are introduced. This is the foundational technique that separates amateur from professional skin rendering.*

06 Value Deepening: Mid-Shadow Layer

Coreshadow areas: deep eye sockets, nostril shadows, right jawline shadow, neck shadow, beneath chin

Medium-heavy pressure in shadow cores, smaller precise strokes concentrating in deepest areas, careful edge maintenance preventing hard lines

Medium to Heavy pressure

Layer PC1080 Beige Sienna with medium-heavy pressure into deeper shadows, concentrating application in shadow cores while maintaining soft edges. This warm brownish-sienna tone adds essential depth while maintaining warm undertone. The layering sequence (PC1050 cool base + PC1001 warm shadow + PC1080 warm depth) creates dimensional shadow without muddy grey appearance. Preserve form awareness—shadow areas should appear deep enough to convince viewer of structure but warm enough to maintain luminous feeling throughout portrait. No harsh shadow lines; all edges remain soft and blended.

COLORS  PC1080 Beige Sienna

♦ *Each shadow layer should be warmer than the cool undertone but not so warm it appears orange or muddy. Beige Sienna achieves this critical balance—warm enough for natural appearance but earthy enough to maintain shadow believability. This is why color selection matters more than pressure.*

07 Eye Rendering: Base and Structural Foundation

Both eyes including sclera, iris, pupil, eyelid structure, and immediate eye socket area

Precise application respecting anatomical eye structure, tiny deliberate strokes for iris detail, cream applied with light pressure to sclera avoiding highlight area

Light to Medium pressure

Begin eye rendering establishing sclera (white portion) with PC914 Cream, not pure white—cream is vastly more realistic and harmonizes with warm skin tones. Create subtle shadow on sclera with very light PC1051 (20% Warm Grey) following eye structure. Establish iris base with PC906 Copenhagen Blue, applying circular shape with medium pressure following eye anatomy and iris placement. Leave small highlight area (upper pupil) unpainted to maintain luminosity. The cool blue eye color creates essential contrast against warm face—this color temperature contrast is critical for facial harmony and visual interest.

COLORS  PC914 Cream  PC1051 20% Warm Grey  PC906 Copenhagen Blue

♦ *Eyes are the portrait's focal point—establishing cool blue eyes early against warm face prevents the entire portrait from appearing yellowish or muddy. The cool-warm contrast is what makes the warm skin tones appear luminous rather than flat. Establish this contrast early.*

o8 Eye Refinement: Dimensional Depth and Detail

Iris detail, pupil structure, upper eyelid modeling, shadow within eye socket, eye light reflection

Precise small strokes respecting iris anatomy and light direction, light pressure for highlight placement creating appearance, deliberate mark-making for pupil depth

Medium to Heavy in pupil area, Light elsewhere pressure

Deepen iris with second application of PC906 Copenhagen Blue, concentrating color toward iris rim and upper portion where shadow naturally occurs. Apply PC1078 Black Cherry (NOT pure black) within and around pupil to create dimensional depth—Black Cherry's magenta undertone creates more natural pupil appearance than flat black. Model upper eyelid with PC1052 (30% Warm Grey) to show eyelid structure and thickness. Add tiny PC914 Cream highlight in upper pupil for light reflection creating life-like luminosity. This multi-layer approach transforms flat circles into dimensional eyes with apparent moisture and depth.

COLORS

■ PC906 Copenhagen Blue

■ PC1078 Black Cherry

■ PC1052 30% Warm Grey

■ PC914 Cream

◆ *Black Cherry instead of pure black is a hallmark of photorealistic rendering—the magenta undertone catches light more naturally than neutral black. This single color choice creates more believable pupils than entire other techniques. Don't substitute with pure black from other brands; Prismacolor's unique color formulations are why it dominates professional portraiture.*

09 Nose Structure & Shadow Enhancement

Nosebridge, nostril areas, underside of nose, nose-to-face transition, subtle shadow on nose

Layered approach with directional strokes following nose structure, medium pressure concentrating in shadow areas, light pressure on highlighted areas maintaining soft quality

Light to Medium pressure

Refine nose form using layered approach: establish bridge highlight with PC914 Cream where light hits highest point, apply PC939 Peach to mid-nose plane. Deepen nostril areas and underside with PC1031 Henna overlaid onto PC1001 Salmon Pink creating warm-brown nostril shadows. Nostril shadow benefits from PC1078 Black Cherry (cool dark) mixed with warm brown undertone—this warm-cool mix in confined shadow space creates naturalistic appearance. Build nose form gradually with multiple layers rather than heavy single application. Respect soft light quality—avoid harsh lines; use value transitions to suggest form.

COLORS

PC914 Cream

PC939 Peach

PC1031 Henna

PC1001 Salmon Pink

PC1078 Black Cherry

◆ *Noses appear flat with harsh shadows—the secret is warm-cool layering in confined space. Nostril shadow should appear deep enough to convince but warm enough to belong to same luminous face. Henna over Salmon Pink with subtle Black Cherry accent achieves this perfectly—it reads as shadow, not black hole.*

IO Lip Rendering: Foundation and Dimensional Color

Upper lip, lower lip, mouth line definition, lip shadow, and immediate lip area

Directional strokes following lip contours, medium pressure building saturation gradually, emphasizing upper lip highlight area with lighter pressure, careful edge softening

Medium pressure

Establish lips using PC928 Blush Pink as foundation with medium pressure, carefully following natural lip contours and shape. Layer PC929 Pink into lower lip and shadow areas creating dimensional form and subtle deepening. Apply PC1001 Salmon Pink to shadow side (right lip if light source from left) maintaining warm undertone even in shadow. Preserve highlight area on upper lip by applying lighter color there—lips should be among most saturated areas of portrait. Build saturation gradually through multiple transparent layers rather than heavy single application. Lips provide color anchor and naturally draw viewer attention—render with sophistication and restraint.

COLORS

 PC928 Blush Pink

 PC929 Pink

 PC1001 Salmon Pink

♦ *Lips are the most difficult feature to render subtly—the common error is making them cartoonishly pink. Blush Pink base appears almost natural skin tone, with Pink serving as saturation increase rather than dramatic color shift. Professional portraits result from restraint and confidence in understatement rather than overworking.*

II Transition & Color Coherence Layer

All facial planes, especially transitional areas between light, midtone, and shadow zones

Light-to-medium pressure glaze following facial contours, directional strokes maintaining form awareness, allowing paper texture to remain visible creating texture interest

Light to Medium pressure

Apply PC1085 Peach Beige as unifying transitional glaze across entire face with light-to-medium pressure. This sophisticated color perfectly bridges values and temperatures, sitting between light areas and shadows creating visual coherence. Work over previously established colors, watching transitions become smoother and more integrated. This is the critical 'refinement pass' where portrait shifts from constructed color application to integrated unified rendering. The overlay should remain transparent—paper texture should still show slightly, and underlying layers should remain visible. This single glaze separates student work from gallery-quality sophisticated rendering.

COLORS

■ PC1085 Peach Beige

✦ *This glaze is why advanced portraits appear luminous and professional—rather than continuously layering identical colors (which inevitably muddies), this transitional temperature creates instant visual integration. Professional portrait artists exploit this step instinctively; it's the technique differentiating gallery-quality work from student sketches.*

I2 Shadow Refinement & Chromatic Dark Development

Deep shadow areas: eyesockets, nostril shadows, under-nose shadow, right jawline shadow, neck shadow

Medium-heavy pressure in shadow cores, multiple transparent layers rather than single dark application, careful edge control maintaining softness, small deliberate strokes in confined shadow areas

Medium to Heavy pressure

Intensify shadow depth with careful application of PC943 Burnt Ochre in darkest shadow areas, followed by PC1052 (30% Warm Grey) overlay. This builds chromatic shadow combining both warm and cool components—Burnt Ochre prevents shadows becoming purple or muddy while Warm Grey adds structural cool support. Work carefully maintaining soft edges; hard shadow lines destroy portrait quality instantly. Shadow areas should appear deep enough to convince viewer of form and structure but warm enough to maintain luminous feeling of whole portrait. Multiple transparent layers create depth more effectively than single heavy application.

COLORS

 PC943 Burnt Ochre

 PC1052 30% Warm Grey

♦ *This is where many colored pencil portraits fail—shadows become either too dark/harsh or too blue/purple. Burnt Ochre plus Warm Grey combination keeps shadows readable, warm, and integrated with portrait rather than appearing as separate dark shapes. Shadows should harmonize with light, not fight it.*

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Detail Refinement & Selective Feature Definition

Micro-features: eyelashes, eyebrow definition, nostril corner definition, mouth corners, facial hair texture

Precise mark-making with sharpened pencil points, light pressure throughout, following anatomical direction of features, selective strategic detail placement avoiding overwork

Light pressure

Using sharp pencil points and precise control, refine micro-details selectively and strategically. Apply thin eyelash lines with PC935 Black using careful light pressure—only top lashes require definition; bottom lashes appear as soft shadow areas. Establish eyebrow with PC1031 Henna lines following natural hair direction and growth pattern. Define nostril corners with tiny PC1078 Black Cherry marks suggesting shadow depth. Add mouth corner definition with careful PC1001 Salmon Pink shadow. Refine lip highlight sharpness with PC914 Cream where light strikes directly. Critically avoid overworking—strategic suggestion is more powerful than explicit comprehensive detail.

COLORS

PC935 Black

PC1031 Henna

PC1078 Black Cherry

PC1001 Salmon Pink

PC914 Cream

◆ *Softest, most professional portraits result from strategic detail placement rather than comprehensive detail application everywhere. Define key focal points (eye lashes, eyebrow arch, mouth corners) while allowing other details to remain suggested. This selective approach mimics how human vision naturally focuses on specific features.*

I4

Highlight Layer & Strategic Luminosity Enhancement

Upper cheekbone(mostcritical),foreheadhighlightarea,nosebridge tip, upper eyelid light, upper lip highlight

Light-to-medium pressure, directional application following light direction precisely, placing highlights where light naturally hits convex forms following facial anatomy

Light to Medium pressure

Apply PC914 Cream to brightest highlight areas with light-to-medium pressure, building second layer of luminosity. Strategically place highlights where light strikes facial planes most directly: upper cheekbone (most important highlight in entire portrait), forehead plane, nose bridge tip, eye light reflection, and upper lip highlight. Cream's warm tone makes it vastly superior to pure white for realistic skin highlights. Build highlight areas gradually through multiple light applications rather than single heavy pass. Highlights should appear to glow from within rather than sitting artificially on surface.

COLORS

 PC914 Cream

♦ *Highlight placement is absolutely critical to facial structure—one misplaced highlight destroys years of careful rendering. The upper cheekbone highlight (where zygomatic bone protrudes highest) is most critical; if this single highlight is perfect, viewers perceive good modeling even if other highlights are slightly imperfect.*

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Final Burnishing & Photorealistic Surface Integration

Light to midtone areas: upper cheekbone, forehead planes, upper face, between eyes, nose bridge, upper lip

Heavy pressure burnishing strokes, deliberate directional application following form, selective placement in light areas only, careful edge control preventing artificial appearance

Heavy (true burnishing pressure) pressure

Use PC938 White pencil with deliberate medium-to-heavy pressure to selectively burnish brightest light areas, creating smooth glossy finish characteristic of realistic skin. Apply white only where it appears naturally luminous (cheekbones, forehead, between eyebrows, nose bridge, upper lip highlight)—never apply to shadow areas or entire face. Burnishing pressure unifies underlying layers and seals color into paper creating polished appearance. Work with directional strokes respecting facial form. White overlay should appear integral to portrait rather than drawn on top. This final step gives skin characteristic luminous finish and polishes entire portrait.

COLORS

● PC938 White

◆ *Burnishing is irreversible—plan placement carefully. Professional portraits have selective burnishing only in light areas; over-burnishing makes skin appear plasticky and artificial. Master portraiture appears touched by luminous light rather than covered in white paint. Restraint is the hallmark of professional work.*

Evaluate Your Result

Upload your finished drawing to Claude and use this prompt:

"I followed a colored pencil portrait tutorial. Here's what I was trying to achieve: [describe the portrait].
Here's what I think went well: [your observation].
Here's what I'm not satisfied with: [your concern].
Give me 2-3 specific things to improve and rate the result 1-10."

Guide #007 · Pencil & Prompt

This guide was part of an ongoing series — each one AI-generated, human-executed, fully documented.

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